

Helping Hands

Schools in the US spend more than Rs 25,000 crore annually on technology. Now consider this: Most government schools in India don't even have a clear-cut computer education programme. The obvious question that then comes to mind is: How do we overcome this digital divide?

Global tech giants are spending crores of rupees to educate teachers on technology and provide computer equipment in schools. In fact, the US Department of Education has gone so far as to commission a Rs 50 crore study to research the impact of technology in education. This is possible because schools in the West have all the pieces of infrastructure in place: they have the computers, the connectivity, trained staff and the content.

But the situation is quite different in India. Most schools don't even have basic computing infrastructure to impart computer literacy, let alone use technology as a tool to aid education. Couple this with the fact that not everyone can afford to pay thousands of rupees to a computer training institute and only a small fraction of us actually have access to a PC, and we've got a serious problem.

With computer literacy being a pre-requisite in today's age, it's obvious that we need some sweeping changes to ensure that this digital divide doesn't make our children start life with a disadvantage.

Companies like Intel are making attempts to bridge this gap with their Rs 500 crore 'Teach to the Future' programme, which aims at imparting technology education to 5,00,000 teachers globally. Even though there's a humanitarian angle to all these programmes, these tech companies realise that they need to do this in order to seed their own future.

We too can play an important part in bridging this gap.

Every year we junk thousands of PCs without realising that there might be an educational institution in our neighbourhood that might have tremendous use for our discarded technology. After all, one person's obsolete technology might be another's future meal ticket.

Companies can get in touch with schools and donate their old PCs to help underprivileged children in coming to grips with computers. We can organise charity drives to ensure that every school in our locality has access to computers. The government can offer tax rebates to urge larger companies into donating old PCs. Not-for-profit organisations can be set up to manage collection, refurbishment and grants of donated PCs.

So what if we can't provide the latest and the greatest technology to our schoolchildren? We can at least ensure that they're literate enough to compete in the same race as the rest of the world.



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Note: We at Digit are committed to help bridge this digital divide. Schools and educational institutions that wish to receive technology donations, as well as companies willing to donate their old PCs can write to us and we'll do our best in getting them in touch with each other.



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